FROM THE MANUSCRIPTS
RECOVERED AT ARDENT KEEP

THE BLACKTOWER PAPERS

Being the surviving private writings of

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12 Nerament, 1444

Larrien has told me, for the better part of a year now, that I ought to put more of my thoughts to paper. She claims it might stop me from carrying them all to bed with me. I told her that if ink could quiet a man's mind, scribes would surely be the happiest men alive.

She did not find this especially clever.

Still, here I am, and perhaps there could have been no more fitting day to begin.

A messenger arrived this morning with news from Castonath. Korgus Dookanson is dead, and Corin with him.

I had often prayed to Castellos that I might live to hear the first, and dreaded that I might live to hear the second.

For twenty years we have lived behind Oldhaven's walls, counting those who escaped the Greentide and arguing over what remained of a realm most of us had not seen in years. Survival was once necessity, but somewhere along the way it became habit, and there are still men among the League who would mistake that habit for prudence.

Perhaps I am unfair to them. Fear kept many of us alive.

It also cost us dearly.

There are bargains a desperate man may justify while the enemy stands at his gate. There are fewer excuses once that enemy lies dead, and I suspect that thought troubles some of my fellow counts considerably less than it troubles me.

I have a letter from Lothane sitting unanswered on my desk. He would probably tell me that today, of all days, I ought to allow myself some measure of hope. I expect he is right, though I shall not give him the satisfaction of admitting it until I have replied.

Kalista would agree with him.

She was only six when we fled Castellyr, and I sometimes wonder how much of our old home Kalista truly remembers. To her, the places Larrien and I speak of must be little more than stories. She has grown up among Oldhaven's walls and the camps beyond them, and I suspect she occasionally finds my recollections rather tiresome.

She is hardly a child anymore, though I seem to require reminding of that more often than I should. Her interest in military matters has grown considerably, and I must admit she has developed a rather fine eye for terrain and the movement of troops. Not long ago she took issue with one of my proposed patrol routes, and I spent a good while explaining why I had chosen it before discovering that she had noticed a crossing I had overlooked. I was rather pleased with her, though I suspect I could have done a better job of showing it.

Larrien tells me I ought to encourage her more and correct her less. I suppose there is some wisdom in that, though I have no intention of letting the girl think she has nothing left to learn.

As for the League, I doubt the coming weeks will afford much peace. The soldiers are already asking when we march, while the displaced families want to know when they may finally return home. Even some of the older counts have discovered a remarkable enthusiasm for reclaiming their estates now that Dookanson is safely dead. I can hardly blame them for wanting to act, but the death of one orc, however mighty, has hardly restored Castellyr to us.

There will be plenty of time for councils, arguments and preparations in the days ahead. For this evening, at least, I would rather give some thought to Corin and what her sacrifice has meant for the rest of us.

There is still a bottle of Castonath vintage I managed to save when we fled. I had intended to keep it until we returned home, though tonight seems occasion enough. I think I shall find Larrien and Kalista and open it with them.

1449

[*The exact date has been lost. The year 1449 remains legible.*]

The Clouded Eye have finally submitted, and with considerably less bloodshed than I had feared.

More surprising has been what followed. Their people have shown an unexpected willingness to abandon many of their old practices, and the priests report no shortage of converts to the Regent Court. I had expected years of resistance. Instead, some seem almost impatient to prove that they can live differently.

I shall not object to being pleasantly surprised.

Recolonization farther into Castellyr continues more slowly. The reports are improving, though never quite as quickly as I would like. Another road reopened here, another village resettled there, another field cleared after years beneath weeds and brush. It is difficult not to become impatient when I remember what once stood in those places.

Still, every season more families go east, and fewer come back.

That must count for something.

Larrien says I have developed an unhealthy enthusiasm for reports concerning wells, bridges and grain stores. I told her that someone ought to be enthusiastic about such things.

Still, despite my stubbornness, I find it difficult to argue against her in my own thoughts. Just yesterday—

[*The remainder of this leaf has been destroyed, apparently by rodents. Several following pages are missing.*]

17 Nerament, 1456

Another three offices are to be transferred to Castonath before winter. The treasury objects to the expense, the clerks object to the roads, and half the Counts object to whichever building they have been assigned.

Work on the western quarter continues. Several streets have reopened, trade through the gates is becoming ordinary again, and the reconstruction accounts have grown sufficiently complicated that I have stopped pretending I can follow all of them without assistance.

Fortunately, Kalista can.

More and more of the papers that once reached me directly pass across her desk first now. At some point she seems to have stopped being the girl I allowed to sit quietly at council and become one of the people everyone else waits to hear from.

I am not sure when that happened.

News from the north has been equally good. Lucian led the charge against the Bonecarvers and broke them badly enough that I doubt they will trouble Escann again.

We are to meet this autumn. Apparently he intends to host a masquerade ball, of all things, and has seen fit to invite me. A strange choice for a mercenary captain, though the last decade has contained stranger things.

Still, I see no reason to refuse the vain fellow. Apparently it will be hosted at—

[*The next leaf is missing. The entry resumes some pages later.*]

—though Larrien insists that I am making too much of it.

Kalista is married now, and if all goes well I am to become a grandfather before the year is out.

I find that sentence more unsettling than I expected.

She seems entirely untroubled by the matter. Larrien even less so. The two of them have already begun discussing names, clothes and a dozen other things which apparently require decisions months before the child has had the courtesy to arrive.

I have wisely kept my opinions to myself.

Mostly.

There are moments when I look at Kalista and still see the six-year-old we carried from Castellyr. Then she begins discussing troop movements, grain levies or some point of law with one of the Counts, and the illusion becomes rather difficult to maintain.

[*The final portion of the entry is illegible. Damp has caused the ink to spread almost completely across the lower half of the page.*]

1 Castanmark, 1470

Kalista has taken the two agreements to be copied.

She accused me of naivety this afternoon. Not quite directly, but close enough that pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

Perhaps she is right to be cautious. Lucian has kept faith with us for many years, and Aldred has honoured his word regarding Inner Castanor, but neither fact tells us much about the men who may come after them. Nor, for that matter, can I promise what those who come after me will choose to preserve.

Even so, I am pleased with what was agreed today.

For much of my life diplomacy in Escann meant deciding which danger demanded our attention first. Now we argue over borders, claims and what sort of peace we mean to leave behind. It is hardly a peaceful land yet, but these are better arguments to be having.

Castonath is alive again.

I do not think I shall ever grow accustomed to writing that.

More of the League's work moves there every year, as it should. Ardent Keep still carries much of the burden for now, but Castonath no longer feels like some distant promise we are working toward. People live there. They trade there. They complain about taxes there. In time, I expect more and more of what we have built will follow them.

Oldhaven has become quieter in turn.

That should please me as well. For years its halls and courtyards were crowded with people who had nowhere else to go. Now they do. Families have returned east. Soldiers have followed the frontier. Even offices once thought permanent have packed their records and moved elsewhere.

Yet lately I find myself thinking about Oldhaven more often than Castonath.

The reports began with disappearances.

At first there seemed little reason to connect them. A shepherd who did not return. A traveller missing from the road. A labourer whose family swore he had never willingly spent a night away from home. Escann remains dangerous enough that any one of these things can be explained without much effort.

There have been more since.

The latest letters speak of sounds beyond the walls after dark. Laughter, according to one. Cackling, according to another. The watch has searched the nearby woods more than once and found nothing.

I wish that reassured me.

I know the old agreements.

I did not make them, yet it is my duty to deal with them all the same.

For years there was always something more immediate. War. Resettlement. The tribes. Castonath. Each time it seemed reasonable enough to leave the matter for later.

Larrien once told me that I began this journal because I carried too many thoughts to bed with me.

Twenty-six years later, I appear to have learned very little.

I have ordered the oldest records from Oldhaven brought to Ardent Keep. There are documents among them I have avoided reading carefully for a very long time.

I think it is time I did.